India's relations with the UF, therefore, were much more complex than the simplistic 'proxy thesis'. And this is precisely because of India's tendency to view Afghanistan through a Pakistan-centric lens. India's dilemma of normalising relations with Pakistan, but also undercutting Islamabad's influence in Afghanistan provided the context to India-UF relations. According to Indian analysts, Jaswant Singh's visit to Kandahar during the IC-814 hijacking incident was a signal of India's evolving policy narrative on Afghanistan, that is that India could not do away with the Pashtuns entirely.[69] Not surprisingly, India's distance from the former UF factions only grew after the US-led NATO intervention in 2001. As X concedes, after 2002, India lost its influence in Afghanistan 'by not supporting its friends from the former Northern Alliance.'[70] The gains of the 'great game that we played so successfully in the 1990s in Afghanistan, were lost during Manmohan Singh's government, which fruitlessly went about engaging Pakistan', he argues.[71] For most Indian policymakers, if it was not in India's interest to have a strong Taliban writ in Afghanistan, neither was it in its interest to have a strong UF (or any single ethnic faction) that disturbed the sociopolitical balance of Afghanistan. The dominance of one single interest group would have meant continuous tension. The essence of this strategic outlook and the policy narratives emerging from the same is best seen in India's initiative to influence Qanooni and Abdullah, at the Bonn conference in 2001 to give-up some ministerial positions.[72] Not long after this conference, in yet another u-turn, India switched political support in favour of Karzai, and yet again, risked alienating its friends in the north.

## *The UN fails*

In addition to domestic causes, international attitudes towards the Taliban also strengthened the partisans over the conciliators. On 22 October 1996, the UNSC passed Resolution 1076 calling for 'an end to hostilities, outside interference and supply of arms to the parties of the conflict; [and] denounc[ing] discrimination against women and girls in Afghanistan'.[73] Seen as anathema, the Taliban had failed to legitimise its rule within and outside Afghanistan. Despite being recognised by Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, the Taliban failed to